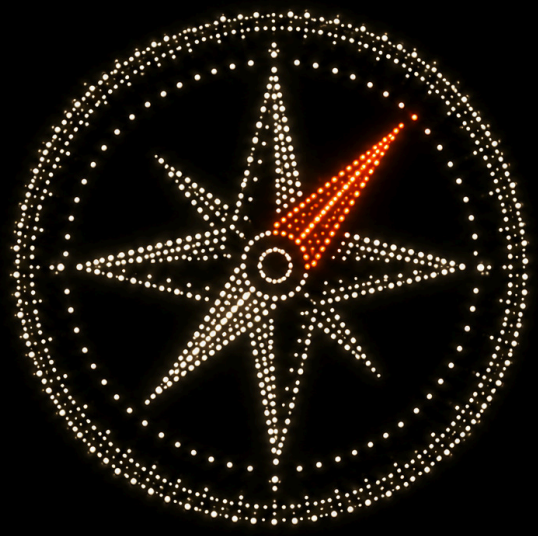
Fintech Hackathon

LONDON · 13 OCTOBER 2026
SINGAPORE GLOBAL NETWORK × GENERATE AT LSE

FIELD GUIDE NO. 02 · THE MENTOR · 18:30–20:30

Ask, don't drive.

Teams get under two hours to build. Good mentors don't fix the code. They ask the one question that makes a team cut scope, name a real user and protect the demo.



1 THE ARC OF THE NIGHT

ONE QUESTION AT EACH STAGE

18:30 · FORM TEAMS
"For whom, with what problem, showing which one flow?"
No sentence, no building. Pair up the solo builders.

18:45 · START BUILDING
"Could anyone build this in a weekend?"
Test originality now, not at 20:00. Scam checkers are the default fraud idea.

19:00 · BUILD CHECK
"What works end to end right now?"
Then: what is the one blocker, and what can you mock instead?

19:45 · FREEZE SCOPE
"What does the 1:30 story actually need?"
No new features, no pivots. Re-run the main flow on fresh data.

20:00 · RECORD
"Who narrates, and where is the backup take?"
Record by 20:15. Entries close at 20:30 sharp.

2 WHERE TEAMS GET STUCK

THE SAME SIX, AT HACKATHONS EVERYWHERE

PROBLEM		FIX
Five features, none finished	→	One person, one problem, one flow. Small and working beats big and broken.
No clear user	→	Name a real person and the money moment where they are stuck.
"Anyone could build this"	→	Ask what is new. Re-use real rails: Open Banking, bureau data, an existing bank app.
AI code that breaks or leaks	→	Re-run the main flow on fresh data. Check secrets, inputs and logins.
The demo fails on the night	→	Mock the slow calls, pre-fill the forms, keep a clean backup recording.
Quiet, or new to all this	→	Agree roles early. Praise small wins. No question is a dumb one.

3 DO, DON'T

THEIR KEYBOARD IS LAVA

✓ DO

- Ask, listen, let the team choose
- Say when you'll be back, and come back
- Help split roles and pick a narrator
- Test originality in the first hour
- One strength before one fix

× DON'T

- Take the keyboard
- Pitch your own idea
- Push a pivot after 19:30
- Hover once a team says it's fine
- Solve it for them

4 THE 1:30 DEMO SCRIPT

WHAT JUDGES WILL WATCH · COACH TEAMS TO THIS

0:00	**PERSON**	*"Meet [name]. [Their money problem, with a number]."*
0:15	**WHY NOW**	*"Until now, [why it couldn't be done]. Now [what changed]."*
0:25	**DEMO**	*One flow, live. The wow moment by 1:00. Narrate what we can't see.*
1:05	**TRUST**	*"Real: [this]. Mocked: [that]. We protect users by [how]."*
1:20	**CLOSE**	*"[Who] pays, because [why]." Stop at 1:30.*

> *"It feels better to have something small working at the end than something big that's in shambles."*
>
> JAREK WOJCIECHOWSKI · ATOMIC OBJECT, ON MENTORING HACKATHON TEAMS

FEWER FEATURES.
ONE PERSON.
ONE PROOF.